

The CHILDREN'S NEWSPAPER

The Story of the World Today for the Men and Women of Tomorrow

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The Children's Newspaper was a very successful newspaper edited by Arthur Mee from 1919 until he died in 1943.

Subtitled *The Story of the World Today for the Men and Women of Tomorrow*, the paper epitomised Mee's values and reflected his twin faiths of Christian ethics and the British Empire. Mee believed that children could be guided to better, more creative lives through education.

The first issue of 21 March 1919 was superficially conventional with text in a fairly dense 5-column layout, interspersed with line drawings, and a back page full of half-tone pictures. Many of the articles were on adult themes (Remarkable airship discovery - Science saves airship from extinction; Britannia rules the waves - Ruin of the Railways by the war; The one hope for the world - Unless the Children support the league, they labour in vain that build it. There were others like *The Warhorse comes home* - *Dumb Hero's Great day*; *Clemenceau and the Schoolgirls*.

A long-running column was Ella Wheeler Wilcox's letter to girls with its sub-headings in the first issue: *The building of Lovely Womanhood*, *the liberty of wartime*, *a girl's great virtues* and *an anchor for years to come*.

The story of the Children's Newspaper is essentially the story of Arthur Mee, and his path from very humble beginnings to being regarded as the greatest living journalist.

Arthur Mee was a most unusual man; he was of small stature, of boundless enthusiasm, and of a deep Christian faith. He was in many ways a typical Edwardian man, proud of the progress in material standards achieved in Britain, and convinced of Britain's mission to transmit the benefits of this progress to other nations all over the world.

He was born in Nottingham in 1875, the son of a railwayman who was a pillar of the local Baptist church. Arthur grew up to have strong principles, a great love of England, and an enthusiasm for the British Empire. His first job was as a copy-holder on the Nottingham Evening Post. He taught himself shorthand in his spare time, and this led to his first job as a reporter on the paper.

From these humble beginnings, his energy and persistence helped him to rise steadily in the world of journalism. In 1903, he had an idea for a new publication, *Who's Who*

this week, and presented it to Sir Alfred Harmsworth. It was not accepted, but a counteroffer was made that Mee should become Features Editor of the Daily Mail. This led on to other projects like the Harmsworth Self-Educator:

A Golden Key to Success in Life and the Harmsworth *History of the World* (which made £20,000 profit for Harmsworth, and got Mee his first motor car).

His next venture, the *Children's Encyclopaedia*, was even more successful and established his reputation. It was a huge achievement. It was compiled in only two years. It was divided into twelve sections, the first entitled *The Child's Book of Familiar Things*, followed by *The Child's Book of Wonder* and then *Nature*, *the Earth*, *All Countries*, *Great Lives*, *Bible Stories*, *Famous Books*, *Stories*, *Poetry*, *School Lessons*, and *Things to Make and Things to Do*.

For example, the *Familiar Things* section included accounts of how a lighthouse is built, how a pendulum works, how wireless telegraphy works, how the Forth Bridge was constructed, what it is like down a coal mine, and many other subjects like clockworks, all with copious illustrations.

His aim for the *Encyclopaedia* was to give the nation's children a firm grasp of subjects such as history and geography, and practical things. It was published as a part-work between 1908 and 1910; it was very successful, and was followed by the *New Children's Encyclopaedia* in March 1910, and in September expanded to a supplement entitled *The Little Paper*, which carried news stories of interest to children. The idea was expanded by Mee in March 1919 when the 12-page weekly tabloid *Children's Newspaper*, priced at 1d, was started. It was designed to keep young people up to date with the latest in world news and science. It was edited by Arthur Maw until he died in 1943, and Hugo Tyerman took over as editor.

Tyerman started to modernise the paper by adding features on television and interviews with sporting personalities. After the war, competition became intense.

Arthur's achievement was to present knowledge in a comprehensive form to those who had become literate as a result of the 1871 Education Act, but whose education had ended at 14, leaving them aware of the opportunities of life but unable to exploit them to the full.

ADDITIONAL NOTES

Children's Newspaper

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Source: Original research

Additional note: This cartoon appeared in the first issue and is printed here for your interest.

